

## Day 4 — Qualities Sort

**Module:** Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

### Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students sort 30 qualities/objects/events into the three *doṣa* buckets with reasoned justification, defending borderline cases.

### Materials

- 30 prepared cards (one quality, food, or event per card — see activity file)
- 3 paper trays / circles on the floor, each labelled with one *doṣa*
- Worksheet for the borderline-cases reflection (last 10 min)

### Vocabulary refreshed

- *vāta*, *pitta*, *kapha*, *guṇa*, *prakṛti*, *vikṛti* — no new vocabulary today; this is consolidation.

### Lesson flow

#### Warm-up (5 min)

- Whole-class chorus: name the three *doṣas* + one quality of each.
- “*Today is the day we get fast at this. Cards, trays, 25 minutes. Go.*”

#### Activity (25 min) — Qualities sort

Full activity in `activities/activity-01-qualities-sort.md`. Summary:

- 3 trays on the floor labelled *vāta*, *pitta*, *kapha*.
- 30 cards in a deck. Each card has a single phrase: “ice cream,” “running,” “dry wind,” “stew,” “shouting in anger,” “deep sleep,” etc.
- Class works in pairs. Each pair draws 6 cards in turn. They place each card on a tray and write a 1-line *why* in their notebook.
- After 15 min, swap pairs. Each pair reads aloud one card placement that’s *not obvious* and defends it. Other pairs can disagree.
- The teacher keeps a tally on the board of cards where pairs disagreed.

#### Core debrief (10 min)

1. **Which cards were tricky?** Discuss the top 3 disagreed-on cards.
2. **The framework’s limits.** Some objects are *multiple* — a hot chocolate is *pitta* (hot) AND *kapha* (heavy, milky, sweet). That’s fine. The framework doesn’t claim a clean one-to-one match. Most real things are mixes.
3. **The *guṇa* principle** (state the rule):

Like increases like. To *balance* a *doṣa*, use the *opposite* quality.

Examples:

- *Vāta* (dry, cold) is increased by dry crackers and cold weather. Calmed by warm soup and oil massage.
- *Pitta* (hot, sharp) is increased by spicy food and arguments. Calmed by cool milk and a walk in shade.
- *Kapha* (heavy, slow) is increased by heavy oily meals and naps. Calmed by brisk walking and light food.

This is the *guṇa* principle the rest of Ayurveda is built on.

4. **What this is NOT.** It is **not** a prescription for what *you* should eat. Modern nutrition still applies (protein, vitamins, calories). *Doṣa*-aware adjustment is a small overlay on top.

### Wrap-up (5 min)

- One-word exit: “Which *doṣa* do you think you’ve been most around this week — in the room you’re in most, the food you’ve eaten most, the weather?” Sticky note.
- Preview Day 5: “Tomorrow — the day-clock. Which *doṣa* runs when.”

### Student-facing content

**The *guṇa* principle: like increases like.**

If you want to *increase* a *doṣa*, use its qualities. If you want to *calm* a *doṣa*, use the *opposite* qualities.

| Doṣa         | Qualities         | Calmed by                                          |
|--------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <i>vāta</i>  | dry, cold, mobile | warm, moist, steady — warm soup, oil, rest         |
| <i>pitta</i> | hot, sharp, oily  | cool, mild, sweet — milk, coriander, walk in shade |
| <i>kapha</i> | heavy, slow, cool | light, dry, warm — ginger tea, brisk walk          |

**Reminder:** these are observations about *qualities of things*, not prescriptions for *what you should eat*. Modern nutrition still applies.

### Homework

- Write down what you ate at dinner tonight. One line per item describing the *qualities* (heavy/light, hot/cold, dry/oily). Don’t worry about which *doṣa* — just the qualities.

### Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Take your dinner from homework and write which *doṣa* each item is likely to increase. Then ask: did your meal *balance* you, or push you one way?
- **One tier down:** Focus on three cards: ice cream (*kapha*), chili (*pitta*), windy day (*vāta*). Just those three patterns.

## Teacher notes

- The sort activity is high-energy. Set a timer.
- Some pairs will park easy cards quickly and avoid the hard ones. Walk around and hand them a hard one (“here — try this”).
- For cards with genuine ambiguity (e.g. “fresh fruit”), the right answer is “it depends on which fruit, when, and how.” Don’t force a single placement; let the discussion be the lesson.

## Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Concepts only — no direct citation in this lesson. The *guṇa* principle “like increases like” is stated across Caraka, Suśruta, and Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdaya; full citations in `sources.md`.